



The Mandukya Upanishad

माण्डूक्योपनिषत्

The twelve mantras in plain English, with the Sanskrit, the hard words explained, and pictures from everyday life

ATHARVAVEDA · 12 MANTRAS · 206 WORDS

A companion text. It is **not** part of the Mahabharata and not part of the novel in this repository. It is kept here, in its own folder, as a stand-alone reading.

The Mandukya is the shortest of the major Upanishads. In twelve short passages it takes the sound **Om** and uses it as a map of your own mind: waking, dreaming, dreamless sleep, and a fourth thing that runs underneath all three.

On this page you will find, for each passage:

1. the Sanskrit, in Devanagari script;
2. the same Sanskrit in Roman letters (IAST), so you can sound it out;
3. a plain English translation;
4. **Hard words:** what the difficult terms mean;
5. **What it is saying:** a short explanation;
6. **A modern picture:** an everyday comparison to help it land.

The translation says only what the Sanskrit says. Everything under “What it is saying” and “A modern picture” is explanation, not text, and where the explanation comes from a traditional commentator it says so.

How long is it?

Measure	Count
Passages (mantras)	12
Sanskrit words, as written in Devanagari	132
Sanskrit words, with the sound-joins undone	206
Plain English translation below (the translation only, not the notes)	538

Why two Sanskrit counts? Sanskrit runs words together when their sounds meet. This is called *sandhi*, “joining”. So *sarvam hi etat brahma ayam ātmā* is written *sarvaṃ hyetadbrahmāyamātmā*: six words on paper as two. The first count is what you see between the spaces. The second pulls every word apart but keeps compound words (like *ekonaviṃśatimukhaḥ*, “nineteen-mouthed”) whole. The first number can shift a little between printed editions, because editors split the joins in slightly different places. The second is the steadier measure.

The twelve mantras are prose, not metrical verse, even though they are usually called “verses”. Neither count includes the opening words *Harib Om* or the peace chant, which are recited with the text but are not part of it.

Mantra	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	Total
Written words	10	5	7	6	18	10	19	9	11	14	14	9	132
Separate words	23	11	8	8	23	12	29	15	19	23	19	16	206

Where the text comes from

- The Mandukya belongs to the **Atharvaveda**, the fourth of the Vedas.
- The Sanskrit given here is the standard text of twelve mantras, the one on which the teacher **Shankara** (Śaṅkara) wrote his commentary. It was checked word for word against two independent online copies (sanskritdocuments.org and shlokam.org), which agree with each other. The only differences between them are spelling-level: whether a join is written with a space, or ॐ is spelt ओम्. None of them changes the meaning.
- The **Mandukya Karika** of **Gaudapada** (Gauḍapāda) is a separate, later work: 215 verses of explanation in four chapters. It is often printed together with the Upanishad and is sometimes mistaken for part of it. It is not translated here. (One school, that of Madhva, treats some verses of the Karika's first chapter as scripture too. The twelve mantras are what everyone agrees on.)
- How much this little text was valued: the *Muktika Upanishad* (1.26) says, “The Mandukya alone is enough for those who seek freedom.”

The English translation on this page is new, made directly from the Sanskrit for this repository.

Key words at a glance

You will meet these again and again. Each is explained in more detail at the passage where it first appears.

Word	Say it	Plain meaning
Om (<i>om, onkāra</i>)	“om”	The sacred sound. Here it stands for everything that is.
Akshara (<i>akṣara</i>)	“uk-sha-ra”	A syllable. The same word also means “that which does not wear away”.
Brahman	“brah-mun”	The one Reality behind everything. Not a god with a face, and not the god Brahma.
Atman (<i>ātman</i>)	“aat-mun”	The Self: what you really are, underneath body and thoughts.
Pada (<i>pāda</i>)	“paa-da”	A foot, or a quarter. The Self is said to have four.
Matra (<i>mātrā</i>)	“maa-traa”	A measure; here, one unit of sound. Om has three: A, U, M.
Prajna (<i>prajñā, prajñā</i>)	“praj-nya”	Awareness, knowing.
Vaishvanara (<i>vaiśvānara</i>)	“vysh-vaa-na-ra”	“Common to all people”: the Self as the waker.
Taijasa (<i>taijasa</i>)	“tie-ja-sa”	“The shining one”: the Self as the dreamer.
Prajna (<i>prājñā</i>)	“praaj-nya”	“The knowing one”: the Self in deep, dreamless sleep.
The Fourth (<i>caturtha</i>)	“cha-tur-tha”	What is left when you look past all three states.
Prapancha (<i>prapañca</i>)	“pra-pun-cha”	The world “spread out” into many separate things.
Advaita	“ud-vy-ta”	“Not two”: without a second.
Shiva (<i>śiva</i>)	“shi-va”	Here an adjective: good, kind, blessed. Not the name of the god.

The peace chant

Before and after studying the Upanishads of the Atharvaveda, students traditionally recite this prayer. The *Muktika Upanishad* names it as the chant for this group, which includes the Mandukya. It comes from the Rigveda (1.89.8–9). It is **not** one of the twelve mantras and is not counted above.

ॐ भद्रं कर्णेभिः शृणुयाम देवाः । भद्रं पश्येमाक्षभिर्यजत्राः ।
 स्थिरैरङ्गैस्तुष्टुवांसस्तनूभिः । व्यशेम देवहितं यदायुः ॥
 स्वस्ति न इन्द्रो वृद्धश्रवाः । स्वस्ति नः पूषा विश्ववेदाः ।
 स्वस्ति नस्तार्क्ष्यो अरिष्टनेमिः । स्वस्ति नो बृहस्पतिर्दधातु ॥
 ॐ शान्तिः शान्तिः शान्तिः ॥

*om bhadraṃ karṇebhiḥ śṛṇuyāma devāḥ, bhadraṃ paśyemākṣabhir yajatrāḥ, sthirair aṅgais tuṣṭuvāṃsas
 tanūbhiḥ, vyaśema devahitaṃ yad āyuh. svasti na indro vṛddhaśravāḥ, svasti naḥ pūṣā viśvavedāḥ, svasti na
 tārkṣyo ariṣṭanemiḥ, svasti no bṛhaspatir dadhātu. om śāntiḥ śāntiḥ śāntiḥ.*

Om. Gods, may our ears hear what is good. Holy ones, may our eyes see what is good. With steady limbs and bodies, singing your praise, may we live out the life the gods have given us.

May Indra, whose fame has grown great, keep us well. May Pushan, who knows all things, keep us well. May Tarkshya, whose wheel-rim is never broken, keep us well. May Brihaspati keep us well.

Om. Peace, peace, peace.

Why “peace” three times? A common traditional explanation is that it asks for peace from three kinds of trouble: trouble from within (illness, worry), trouble from other creatures, and trouble from forces beyond anyone’s control (storms, earthquakes). That is a later explanation, not something the chant itself says.

The Upanishad

Recitation traditionally begins with the words हरिः ॐ (*hariḥ om*), a short call to the divine before any sacred text.

MANTRA 1

Everything is Om

1

ओमित्येतदक्षरमिदं सर्वं तस्योपव्याख्यानं भूतं भवद्भविष्यदिति सर्वमोङ्कार एव ।
यच्चान्यत्त्रिकालातीतं तदप्योङ्कार एव ॥ १ ॥

*omityetadākṣaramidaṃ sarvaṃ tasyopavyākhyānaṃ bhūtaṃ bhavadbhaviṣyaditi sarvamōṅkāra eva |
yaccānyatṭrikālātītaṃ tadapyōṅkāra eva || 1 ||*

TRANSLATION

Om: this sound is all that is. Here is a closer account of it. What has been, what is, and what will be: all of it is simply Om. And whatever else there is, beyond these three times, that too is simply Om.

HARD WORDS

- **Akshara** (*akṣara*): “syllable”. It also means “imperishable”, from *a-* “not” and *kṣara* “wearing away”. The double meaning is on purpose: the syllable Om stands for what never wears away.
- **Idam sarvam**: “all this”. A standard Upanishad phrase for the whole world you can see, hear and touch.
- **Upavyakhyana** (*upavyākhyāna*): a “closer explanation”. The text is telling you that the rest of the Upanishad unpacks this first line.
- **Trikala-atita** (*trikālātīta*): “gone beyond the three times”, past, present and future.

WHAT IT IS SAYING

The Upanishad opens with one bold claim. There is one sound, Om, and it stands for *everything*: everything in time, and whatever lies outside time as well. A name and the thing it names are close partners. Here Om is treated as the name of the whole of reality.

◆ A MODERN PICTURE

Think of a film on a streaming service. When you watch it, you see only one moment at a time: the past scenes are gone and the future scenes have not come yet. But the whole film, beginning to end, already exists as one file. And there is something that is not in any scene at all: the screen it plays on. The Upanishad says Om covers all of it: every scene, past, present and future, *and* the screen.

MANTRA 2

The Self is Brahman, and it has four quarters

2

सर्वं ह्येतद्ब्रह्मायमात्मा ब्रह्म सोऽयमात्मा चतुष्पात् ॥ २ ॥

sarvaṃ hyetadbrahmāyamātmā brahma so'yamātmā catuspāt || 2 ||

TRANSLATION

All this is Brahman. This Self is Brahman. And this Self has four quarters.

HARD WORDS

- **Brahman**: the one Reality behind and within everything. It comes from a root meaning “to grow, to be great”. It is not the creator god Brahma, and not a person.
- **Atman** (*ātman*): “the Self”. Not your name, body, job or personality, but the plain fact of *being aware* that sits underneath all of those.
- **Ayam atma** (*ayam ātmā*): “this Self”. The word *ayam*, “this”, is pointing close by: to your own Self, right here.
- **Chatushpat** (*catuspāt*): “four-footed”, “having four quarters”. *Pāda* means both “foot” and “quarter” (as a quarter-line of a verse, or a quarter of a coin).

WHAT IT IS SAYING

In one breath the text makes two huge statements. First, the whole universe is Brahman. Second, your own Self is that same Brahman: what is deepest in you and what is deepest in everything are one and the same. “This Self is Brahman” (*ayam ātmā brahma*) is counted by the tradition as one of the four “great sayings” of the Upanishads.

Then it says the Self has four “quarters”, and the next five mantras describe them. The commentator Shankara adds a helpful warning: these are not like the four legs of a cow, four separate parts standing side by side. They are like the four quarters of an old coin, where you count the first three up into the fourth, and so reach the whole.

◆ A MODERN PICTURE

Think of the air inside a balloon and the air in the room. The rubber skin makes it *look* as if there are two airs, “mine” and “the room’s“. Take away the skin and you see there was only ever one air. The Upanishad says your Self and Brahman are like that.

For the four quarters, think of one person seen four ways: at their desk by day, in their dreams at night, in deep sleep, and as the one who was there through all three. Not four people. One person, four ways of being found.

MANTRA 3

The first quarter, the waker

3

जागरितस्थानो बहिष्प्रज्ञः सप्ताङ्ग एकोनविंशतिमुखः स्थूलभुग्वैश्वानरः प्रथमः पादः ॥

३ ॥

jāgaritasthāno bahiṣprajñaḥ saptaṅga ekonaviṁśatimukhaḥ sthūlabhugvaiśvānaraḥ prathamah pādah || 3 ||

TRANSLATION

The first quarter is Vaishvanara, “the one common to all people”. Its home is the waking state. Its awareness faces outward. It has seven limbs and nineteen mouths, and it feeds on the solid world.

HARD WORDS

- **Jagarita-sthana** (*jāgarita-sthāna*): “whose place is waking”.
- **Bahish-prajna** (*bahiṣ-prajña*): “aware of the outside”.
- **Sapta-anga** (*saptaṅga*): “seven-limbed”. The text does not list the seven. Shankara explains them from an older passage (*Chandogya Upanishad* 5.18.2) that pictures the universe as one cosmic person: the sky as the head, the sun as the eye, the wind as the breath, space as the trunk, water as the bladder, the earth as the feet, and the sacred fire as the mouth.
- **Ekonavimshati-mukha** (*ekonaviṁśati-mukha*): “nineteen-mouthed” (literally “twenty-less-one”). Again the text gives no list. Shankara counts them as the ways we take in and act on the world: the five senses, the five powers of action (speech, handling, moving, excreting, reproducing), the five vital breaths, and the mind, the intellect, the sense of “I”, and memory or thought.
- **Sthula-bhuk** (*sthūla-bhuj*): “eater of the gross”. *Sthūla* means solid, coarse, physical: things you can bump into.
- **Vaishvanara** (*vaiśvānara*): from *viśva* “all” and *nara* “person”: “belonging to all people”. The waking world is the one we all share.

WHAT IT IS SAYING

This is you, now, awake. Your attention points outward at a physical world. You take that world in through many “mouths”, your senses and faculties, and you “feed” on it: you see it, touch it, use it. This state is called “common to all” because the waking world is the one place where everyone meets.

◆ A MODERN PICTURE

Think of a computer's input ports: keyboard, mouse, camera, microphone, network cable. The nineteen "mouths" are the ports through which the waking world streams in. And the waking world is like an online game with a shared server: you and millions of others log into the *same* world, see the same street, and can bump into each other there.

MANTRA 4

The second quarter, the dreamer

4

स्वप्नस्थानोऽन्तःप्रज्ञः सप्ताङ्ग एकोनविंशतिमुखः प्रविविक्तभुक्तैजसो द्वितीयः पादः ॥ ४

॥

svapnasthāno'ntahprajñah saptāṅga ekonaviṁśatimukhaḥ praviviktabhuktaijaso dvitīyaḥ pādah || 4 ||

TRANSLATION

The second quarter is Taijasa, “the shining one”. Its home is the dream state. Its awareness faces inward. It has seven limbs and nineteen mouths, and it feeds on the subtle world.

HARD WORDS

- **Svapna-sthana** (*svapna-sthāna*): “whose place is dream”.
- **Antah-prajna** (*antah-prajña*): “aware of the inside”.
- **Pravivikta-bhuk** (*pravivikta-bhuj*): “eater of the fine, the separate”. The objects of a dream are made of mind-stuff alone, finer than solid things and set apart from the outer world.
- **Taijasa**: from *tejas*, “light, brilliance”. In a dream there is no sun, yet the scenes are lit. The mind supplies its own light.

WHAT IT IS SAYING

When you dream, your awareness turns inward. You still have a body in the dream, and you still see, hear, walk and talk: the same “seven limbs and nineteen mouths”. But everything you meet is made by your own mind, and lit by your own mind.

◆ A MODERN PICTURE

A dream is like a virtual-reality headset where your own mind is the headset, the game designer, the graphics card *and* the player. You can drive a car you don’t own through a city that doesn’t exist, meet people who never lived, and it all feels completely real until you wake. And unlike the shared server of waking life, this game runs on one machine only: nobody else can enter your dream.

MANTRA 5

The third quarter, deep sleep

5

यत्र सुप्तो न कञ्चन कामं कामयते न कञ्चन स्वप्नं पश्यति तत्सुषुप्तम् ।
 सुषुप्तस्थान एकीभूतः प्रज्ञानघन एवानन्दमयो ह्यानन्दभुक्चेतोमुखः प्राज्ञस्तृतीयः पादः
 ॥ ५ ॥

*yatra supto na kañcana kāmam kāmayate na kañcana svapnam paśyati tatsuṣṣuṣṭam | suṣṣuṣṭasthāna ekībhūtaḥ
 prajñānaghana evānandamayo hyānandabhukcetomukhaḥ prājñastṛtīyaḥ pādah || 5 ||*

TRANSLATION

Deep sleep is when the sleeper wants nothing at all and sees no dream at all. The third quarter is Prajna, “the knowing one”. Its home is deep sleep. In it everything has become one. It is simply a solid mass of awareness. It is made of bliss, and it tastes bliss. Awareness is its mouth.

HARD WORDS

- **Sushupta** (*suṣṣuṣṭa*): “deep sleep”, sleep with no dreams.
- **Ekibhuta** (*ekībhūta*): “become one”. The many things of waking and dream have all melted together.
- **Prajnana-ghana** (*prajñāna-ghana*): “a mass of awareness”. *Ghana* means solid, dense, packed together, as in a thick cloud. Nothing is separate or picked out. It is awareness with no *object*.
- **Ananda-maya** (*ānanda-maya*): “made of bliss”; **ananda-bhuk** (*ānanda-bhuj*): “enjoyer of bliss”. *Ānanda* is deep joy or ease, not excitement.
- **Cheto-mukha** (*ceto-mukha*): “whose mouth is awareness”. Two readings are possible. Plainly, it takes in nothing but awareness itself. Shankara reads *mukha* as “doorway”: deep sleep is the door through which awareness goes out again into dream and waking.
- **Prajna** (*prājñā*): “the knowing one”. The name is a little surprising, since in deep sleep we don’t know anything. The point is that awareness is still there, only with nothing in front of it.

WHAT IT IS SAYING

In dreamless sleep, desire stops and pictures stop. You are not *nothing*: you are awareness with all the furniture removed. And it feels good. Everyone longs for deep sleep, and no one complains of having slept too well. This mantra says that ease comes from what you are, not from anything you had.

◆ A MODERN PICTURE

Think of a laptop with its lid closed. Every file and program is still there, saved, but nothing is open on the screen and nothing is running in front of you. Open the lid and the whole desktop springs back. And there is a famous point for reflection that teachers of this text have long used: when you wake from a deep sleep you say, “I slept so well, I knew nothing at all.” But if you were not there, who noticed that you knew nothing?

MANTRA 6

What the third quarter really is

6

एष सर्वेश्वर एष सर्वज्ञ एषोऽन्तर्याम्येष योनिः सर्वस्य प्रभवाप्ययौ हि भूतानाम् ॥ ६ ॥

eṣa sarveśvara eṣa sarvajña eṣo'ntaryāmyeṣa yoniḥ sarvasya prabhavāpyayau hi bhūtānām || 6 ||

TRANSLATION

This is the lord of all. This is the knower of all. This is the controller within. This is the womb of everything, for it is where beings come from and where they go back to.

HARD WORDS

- **Sarveshvara** (*sarveśvara*): “lord of all”.
- **Sarvajna** (*sarvajña*): “all-knowing”.
- **Antaryami** (*antaryāmin*): “the inner controller”, the one who guides every being from inside.
- **Yoni**: “womb, source, birthplace”.
- **Prabhava-apyaya** (*prabhava-apyaya*): “coming forth and going back”, origin and dissolution.

WHAT IT IS SAYING

“This” points back to the third quarter, the deep-sleep Self. That can seem strange: how can deep sleep be the lord of all? Think about what happens every morning. Your dream-world and your waking world both spring out of deep sleep, and at night they both sink back into it. On the scale of the universe, the same seed-state is where all beings come from and where they return. Seen that way, it is the source and the ruler of everything that unfolds from it. Shankara reads this as the Self in its role as God, the cause of the world.

◆ A MODERN PICTURE

A seed and a tree. The whole oak, with every leaf and branch, is folded up in the acorn, not yet spread out. The acorn is the “womb” of the tree. The third quarter is like the acorn of both your dream-world and your waking world.

MANTRA 7

The Fourth

7

नान्तःप्रज्ञं न बहिष्प्रज्ञं नोभयतःप्रज्ञं न प्रज्ञानघनं न प्रज्ञं नाप्रज्ञम् ।
 अदृष्टमव्यवहार्यमग्राह्यमलक्षणमचिन्त्यमव्यपदेश्यमेकात्मप्रत्ययसारं प्रपञ्चोपशमं
 शान्तं शिवमद्वैतं चतुर्थं मन्यन्ते स आत्मा स विज्ञेयः ॥ ७ ॥

*nāntahprajñam na bahiṣprajñam nobhayataḥprajñam na prajñānaghaṇam na prajñam nāprajñam |
 adrṣṭamavyavahāryamagrāhyamalakṣaṇamacintyam avyapadeśyamekātmapratyayasāraṁ
 prapañcopaśamaṁ śāntaṁ śivamadvaitaṁ caturthaṁ manyante sa ātmā sa vijñeyaḥ || 7 ||*

TRANSLATION

It is not aware of what is inside, not aware of what is outside, and not aware of both together. It is not a mass of awareness. It is not knowing, and it is not unknowing. It cannot be seen. It cannot be used or dealt with. It cannot be grasped. It has no marks to know it by. It cannot be thought of. It cannot be put into words. Its very substance is the sure sense of one single Self. In it the spread-out world falls still. It is peace. It is good. It is one without a second. This is what the wise take to be the Fourth. That is the Self. That is what is to be known.

HARD WORDS

- **Na ... na ... na:** “not ... not ... not”. The first six phrases say what the Fourth is *not*: not the dreamer (aware inside), not the waker (aware outside), not the in-between state of half-waking, not deep sleep (the mass of awareness), not a knower of things, and not a blank unconscious lump either.
- **Avyavaharya** (*avyavahārya*): “not open to dealings”. You cannot pick it up, trade it, point at it, or do anything with it.
- **Alakshana** (*alakṣaṇa*): “without marks”. It has no colour, shape, size or feature by which to recognise it.
- **Avyapadeshya** (*avyapadeśya*): “that cannot be named or pointed out”.
- **Ekatma-pratyaya-sara** (*ekātma-pratyaya-sāra*): “whose essence is the sense of the one Self”. Shankara explains: in waking, dream and sleep there is always the same one “I am”, and that single, unbroken awareness is how the Fourth is known.
- **Prapancha-upashama** (*prapañca-upaśama*): “the stilling of the spread-out world”. *Prapañca* is the world spread out into many; the word is related to “five” (*pañca*), and is often linked to the five elements. *Upaśama* is “calming, going quiet”.

- **Shanta** (*śānta*): “at peace”. **Shiva** (*śiva*): “good, blessed, kind”. **Advaita**: “not two”.
- **Chaturtha** (*caturtha*): “the fourth”. The famous word *turiya*, also “fourth”, is **not** used in the Mandukya itself. It comes from later writers, including Gaudapada.
- **Manyante**: “they consider, they think of it as”. The text is reporting what the wise hold.

WHAT IT IS SAYING

This is the heart of the Upanishad. The Fourth is not a fourth *state* that comes after sleep, like a fourth room at the end of a corridor. It is what was present in all three rooms all along: the bare awareness in which waking, dreaming and sleeping come and go.

That is why the text describes it almost entirely by saying “not”. Any description would turn it into an object, something seen, and it is the one that does the seeing. So the text strips away every label until only the Self is left. And then it ends with a command in two words: *sa vijñeyah*, “that is to be known”. Everything before this was the map. This is the place the map points to.

◆ A MODERN PICTURE

Think of a cinema screen. The film shows a fire, and the screen does not burn. It shows a flood, and the screen does not get wet. It shows a night scene, and the screen does not go dark in itself. The screen is not one of the scenes. It is what every scene appears on. When the film ends, the screen is still there.

Or think of a string of pearls. The pearls are waking, dreaming and sleeping. The thread runs through every pearl, holds them all together, and is hidden by them. The *Bhagavad Gita* (7.7) uses this same image: “All this is strung on me, like pearls on a thread.” The Fourth is the thread.

MANTRA 8

The Self as the sound Om

8

सोऽयमात्माध्यक्षरमोङ्कारोऽधिमात्रं पादा मात्रा मात्राश्च पादा अकार उकारो मकार इति

॥ ८ ॥

so'yamātmādhyaṣṣaramoṅkāro'dhimātraṃ pādā mātṛā mātṛāśca pādā akāra ukāro makāra iti || 8 ||

TRANSLATION

This same Self, taken as a syllable, is Om. Taken part by part: the quarters are the parts, and the parts are the quarters. The parts are the sound A, the sound U, and the sound M.

HARD WORDS

- **Adhyakshara** (*adhyakṣara*): “with regard to the syllable”, looking at the Self in terms of sound.
- **Adhimatra** (*adhimātra*): “with regard to the measures”, looking at it part by part.
- **Matra** (*mātrā*): a measure, a unit of sound.
- **Akara, ukara, makara** (*akāra, ukāra, makāra*): “the sound A”, “the sound U”, “the sound M”. *-kāra* just means “the sound of”.

WHAT IT IS SAYING

Now the Upanishad joins its two themes, Om and the Self. In Sanskrit, when A and U meet, they blend into O, so “A-U-M” is spoken as “Om”. The text matches each sound to one of the quarters. Mantras 9 to 12 go through them one by one.

◆ A MODERN PICTURE

Try it. Say “Om” very slowly: “aaa ... ooo ... mmm”. Notice your mouth. On A it is open. On U it rounds and moves forward. On M the lips close and the sound hums inside. Then, when the sound stops, there is silence. Four things: three sounds and the silence after them. Keep that in mind for the next four mantras.

MANTRA 9

A is the waker

9

जागरितस्थानो वैश्वानरोऽकारः प्रथमा मात्राऽऽप्तेरादिमत्त्वाद्वाऽऽप्नोति ह वै
सर्वान्कामानादिश्च भवति य एवं वेद ॥ ९ ॥

*jāgaritasthāno vaiśvānaro'kāraḥ prathamā mātṛā'pterādimattvādvā'pnoti ha vai sarvāṅkā mānādiśca bhavati
ya evaṃ veda || 9 ||*

TRANSLATION

Vaishvanara, whose home is waking, is the sound A, the first part. This is because A reaches everywhere, or because A comes first. Whoever knows this reaches all their desires and becomes first.

HARD WORDS

- **Apti** (*āpti*): “reaching, pervading, getting”.
- **Adimattva** (*ādimattva*): “being first, having a beginning”.
- **Ya evam veda** (*ya evaṃ veda*): “whoever knows this”. A stock phrase in the Vedas, used to announce the reward that comes from a piece of knowledge.

WHAT IT IS SAYING

The text plays on sounds, as the Vedas often do. The reasons it gives for A both start with A: *āpti*, “reaching”, and *ādi*, “first”. A reaches everywhere: in Sanskrit script every consonant carries a built-in A (*ka, ga, ta ...*), so A is hidden in almost every sound you make. And A is first: it is the first letter of the Sanskrit alphabet. In the *Bhagavad Gita* (10.33), Krishna says, “Among letters, I am A.”

The waking state is like that. It is the first state, the one we take as the starting point, and it seems to reach everywhere. The promise at the end is a traditional “fruit” statement. It says what the one who understands this will gain.

◆ A MODERN PICTURE

A is the first letter not only in Sanskrit but in the Greek, Latin and English alphabets too. It is also the first sound most of us make when we open our mouths without shaping them, as in “ah” at the doctor’s. The waking world is like that “ah”: the open, default, first setting.

MANTRA 10

U is the dreamer

10

स्वप्नस्थानस्तैजस उकारो द्वितीया मात्रोत्कर्षादुभयत्वाद्वोत्कर्षति ह वै ज्ञानसन्ततिं
समानश्च भवति नास्याब्रह्मवित्कुले भवति य एवं वेद ॥ १० ॥

*svapnasthānastaijasa ukāro dvitīyā mātrotkarṣādubhayatvādvotkarṣati ha vai jñānasantatiṃ samānaśca
bhavati nāsyābrahmavitkule bhavati ya evaṃ veda || 10 ||*

TRANSLATION

Taijasa, whose home is dream, is the sound U, the second part. This is because U is raised higher, or because U stands between the two. Whoever knows this raises the flow of knowledge higher and becomes balanced. In their family no one is born who does not know Brahman.

HARD WORDS

- **Utkarsha** (*utkarṣa*): “raising up, being higher”. U comes after A and is, in that sense, a step above it; dream is a finer, more inward state than waking.
- **Ubhayatva** (*ubhayatva*): “being of both”, standing in the middle. U sits between A and M, just as dream sits between waking and deep sleep.
- **Jnana-santati** (*jñāna-santati*): “the stream of knowledge”, knowledge that flows on and continues.
- **Samana** (*samāna*): “equal, the same, even”. The text does not say equal to what. It can be read as “even-minded”, or as “treated as an equal by everyone”. This translation takes the first.
- **Abrahmavit** (*abrahmavid*): “one who does not know Brahman”.

WHAT IT IS SAYING

Again the reasons sound like the letter: *utkarṣa* and *ubhaya* both start with U. Dream is the middle state. It borrows its pictures from waking and melts back into sleep, so it is a bridge between the two. The reward promised is a spiritual one: understanding grows and is handed on, so that wisdom runs in the family.

◆ A MODERN PICTURE

U is like the middle layer of a sandwich, or the middle stop on a train line. You cannot get from waking to deep sleep without passing through the dream-station, however briefly. And “knowledge flowing on in the family” is like a household where the love of learning is passed down, so that every child grows up with it.

MANTRA 11

M is deep sleep

11

सुषुप्तस्थानः प्राज्ञो मकारस्तृतीया मात्रा मितेरपीतेर्वा मिनोति ह वा इदं सर्वमपीतिश्च
भवति य एवं वेद ॥ ११ ॥

*suṣuptasthānaḥ prājño makārastrīyā mātṛā miterapītervā minoti ha vā idaṁ sarvamaṇītiśca bhavati ya evaṁ
veda || 11 ||*

TRANSLATION

Prajna, whose home is deep sleep, is the sound M, the third part. This is because M measures, or because in M everything merges. Whoever knows this measures all this world and becomes the place where it merges.

HARD WORDS

- **Miti:** “measuring”. **Minoti:** “measures”.
- **Apiti** (*apīti*): “going into, merging, dissolving”.

WHAT IT IS SAYING

The word-play is *miti*, “measuring”, which starts with M. Shankara gives a vivid explanation. When you chant “Om” again and again, A and U seem to go *into* M as the lips close, and come *out* of it again as the next Om begins. It is like grain being poured into a measuring pot and poured out again. Deep sleep does the same with the waking and dream worlds: every night they pour into it, and every morning they pour out.

The one who understands this “measures” the world, meaning they see it for what it is, and becomes the place where it is gathered in.

◆ A MODERN PICTURE

Think of pressing “save and close” on every open window. All the work is gathered up and folded into one place, and nothing is lost. The closing M, with the lips shut and the sound humming inside, is that gathering.

MANTRA 12

The silence after Om

12

अमात्रश्चतुर्थोऽव्यवहार्यः प्रपञ्चोपशमः शिवोऽद्वैत एवमोङ्कार आत्मैव
संविशत्यात्मनाऽऽत्मानं य एवं वेद ॥ १२ ॥

*amātraścaturtho'vyavahāryaḥ prapañcōpaśamaḥ śivo'dvaita evamoṅkāra ātmaiva saṁviśatyātmanā'ātmānam
ya evaṁ veda || 12 ||*

TRANSLATION

The Fourth has no parts. It cannot be dealt with. In it the spread-out world falls still. It is good, and it is one without a second. So Om is the Self itself. Whoever knows this, by their own self enters the Self.

HARD WORDS

- **Amatra** (*amātra*): “without measure, without parts”. The Fourth is not a fourth letter. It has no sound of its own.
- **Samvishati** (*saṁviśati*): “enters, goes home into, merges”.
- **Atmana atmanam** (*ātmanā ātmānam*): “by the Self, into the Self”.

WHAT IT IS SAYING

The three sounds A, U and M match waking, dream and sleep. The Fourth matches no sound. It is the silence out of which Om rises and back into which it falls. So the whole of Om, sounds and silence together, *is* the Self.

The last line is striking. The knower does not travel anywhere or become anything new. They enter the Self *by* the Self, like a wave settling back into the ocean it never left. In recitation the final words *ya evaṁ veda*, “whoever knows this”, are usually said twice, to mark the end of the text.

◆ A MODERN PICTURE

Strike a bell. It rings, the sound swells, fades, and then there is silence. That silence is not “nothing”. It was there before the bell was struck, it held the whole ring from start to finish, and it is still there after. Nothing you do to the bell can break it. The Upanishad’s last word is that the silence is what you are.

The whole map in one table

Quarter	Name	State	Awareness	Feeds on	Sound
1st	Vaishvanara, “common to all”	Waking	Faces outward	The solid world	A
2nd	Taijasa, “the shining one”	Dreaming	Faces inward	The subtle, mind- made world	U
3rd	Prajna, “the knowing one”	Deep sleep	A single mass of awareness	Bliss	M
The Fourth	(no name given)	Not a state: present in all three	Neither inward, outward nor massed	Nothing: the world falls still here	Silence

The translation straight through

For reading without the notes.

1. Om: this sound is all that is. Here is a closer account of it. What has been, what is, and what will be: all of it is simply Om. And whatever else there is, beyond these three times, that too is simply Om.
2. All this is Brahman. This Self is Brahman. And this Self has four quarters.
3. The first quarter is Vaishvanara, “the one common to all people”. Its home is the waking state. Its awareness faces outward. It has seven limbs and nineteen mouths, and it feeds on the solid world.
4. The second quarter is Taijasa, “the shining one”. Its home is the dream state. Its awareness faces inward. It has seven limbs and nineteen mouths, and it feeds on the subtle world.
5. Deep sleep is when the sleeper wants nothing at all and sees no dream at all. The third quarter is Prajna, “the knowing one”. Its home is deep sleep. In it everything has become one. It is simply a solid mass of awareness. It is made of bliss, and it tastes bliss. Awareness is its mouth.
6. This is the lord of all. This is the knower of all. This is the controller within. This is the womb of everything, for it is where beings come from and where they go back to.
7. It is not aware of what is inside, not aware of what is outside, and not aware of both together. It is not a mass of awareness. It is not knowing, and it is not unknowing. It cannot be seen. It cannot be used or dealt with. It cannot be grasped. It has no marks to know it by. It cannot be thought of. It cannot be put into words. Its very substance is the sure sense of one single Self. In it the spread-out world falls still. It is peace. It is good. It is one without a second. This is what the wise take to be the Fourth. That is the Self. That is what is to be known.
8. This same Self, taken as a syllable, is Om. Taken part by part: the quarters are the parts, and the parts are the quarters. The parts are the sound A, the sound U, and the sound M.
9. Vaishvanara, whose home is waking, is the sound A, the first part. This is because A reaches everywhere, or because A comes first. Whoever knows this reaches all their desires and becomes first.
10. Taijasa, whose home is dream, is the sound U, the second part. This is because U is raised higher, or because U stands between the two. Whoever knows this raises the flow of knowledge higher and becomes balanced. In their family no one is born who does not know Brahman.
11. Prajna, whose home is deep sleep, is the sound M, the third part. This is because M measures, or because in M everything merges. Whoever knows this measures all this world and becomes the place where it merges.
12. The Fourth has no parts. It cannot be dealt with. In it the spread-out world falls still. It is good, and it is one without a second. So Om is the Self itself. Whoever knows this, by their own self enters the Self.

Things people often get wrong

- **“Turiya” is not in the text.** The Mandukya calls the Fourth simply *caturtha*, “the fourth”. *Turiya* comes from later writers.
- **Gaudapada’s Karika is not the Upanishad.** The 215 verses of the *Mandukya Karika* are a separate commentary-poem, printed alongside it.
- **The lists of “seven limbs” and “nineteen mouths” are not in the text.** The Upanishad gives only the numbers. The lists come from Shankara’s commentary.
- **The Fourth is not a fourth state.** The text says it is *not* like any of the three. It is what is present through them.
- **The name.** *Māṇḍūkya* is the name of a Vedic line of teachers. *Maṇḍūkā* does mean “frog”, and popular accounts sometimes build a story on that, but the Upanishad itself says nothing about frogs.

Translation choices

A few places where the Sanskrit allows more than one fair reading, and what this translation chose.

- **Mantra 1, *akṣara*:** “sound” or “syllable” in the translation; the second meaning, “imperishable”, is explained in the notes.
- **Mantra 5, *cetomukha*:** “awareness is its mouth”, the literal reading; Shankara’s “doorway” reading is given in the notes.
- **Mantra 7, *manyante*:** “what the wise take to be”. The verb only says “they consider”; “the wise” makes the unnamed subject clear.
- **Mantra 7, *ekātma-pratyaya-sāra*:** “its very substance is the sure sense of one single Self”. *Pratyaya* can mean a thought, a firm conviction, or a means of knowing.
- **Mantra 10, *samāna*:** “balanced”, in the sense of even-minded; the other reading, “treated as an equal”, is given in the notes.
- **Mantra 12, *saṃviśaty ātmanā 'tmānam*:** “by their own self enters the Self”. The same word *ātman* serves both as “one’s own self” and “the Self”; the capital letter marks the second.
- **“They/their”** is used for “whoever knows this” where the Sanskrit uses the grammatical masculine for any person.

Sources

- Sanskrit text: the standard twelve-mantra text of the Mandukya Upanishad, as commented on by Shankara; checked against the copies at sanskritdocuments.org (encoded by M. Giridhar, proofread by John Manetta) and shloka.org. The Sanskrit is ancient and free of copyright.
- Peace chant: Rigveda 1.89.8–9, assigned to the Atharvaveda Upanishads in the *Muktika Upanishad*.
- Traditional explanations are credited to Shankara's commentary (*Māṇḍūkya Upaniṣad Bhāṣya*) where they are used.
- Other passages quoted: *Chandogya Upanishad* 5.18.2; *Bhagavad Gita* 7.7 and 10.33; *Muktika Upanishad* 1.26.
- The English translation and all explanations are original to this repository.